

The Frog and the nightingale by Vikram Seth

The Summary:

The poem tells the story of a frog—the **loud, arrogant** “boss” of Bingle Bog—and a nightingale, a **gifted but shy** singer. When the nightingale’s beautiful singing makes the frog jealous, he pretends to be a world-class music teacher to control her. He exhausts her for profit and fame until she collapses and dies, leaving the frog as the “unrivalled” singer of the bog once again.

The Frog and the Nightingale’ by Vikram Seth tells a fictional story of two animals who sing. One is a **frog**, and the other is a **nightingale**. Though the nightingale’s singing is clearly *preferred by the other animals* over the frog’s singing, the naivety of the nightingale allows the frog—who is “crass” and “bitter”—to manipulate the nightingale into misery through the very thing that the nightingale loved. Essentially, the nightingale did not approach her skill with **confidence** and independence, and because of this, the lesser-talented frog was able to take advantage of the nightingale, ruin the nightingale’s gift, and cause all animals within the vicinity to lose something they enjoyed in favour of something they never appreciated.

These concepts can be linked to human nature in a way that offers a moral to all of us. That moral is to have confidence and grounding, because, without those things, even the most talented of people could be doomed to failure and disaster.

Key Themes and Analysis

Exploitation of Talent: The frog represents selfish, manipulative authority figures who exploit innocent talent (the nightingale) for personal gain.

Art vs. Commercialization: The nightingale sings for joy, but the frog turns her art into a commercial product, taking admission fees, which ruins her authentic voice.

The Danger of Flattery: The nightingale’s downfall is her naivety and her desire to please a critic who has no real musical talent.

The Mob Mentality: The other creatures of the bog are fickle; they love the new sound but easily submit to the frog’s dominance.

Lack of Self-Confidence: Because the nightingale didn’t believe in her own talent, she let a “brainless” frog tell her how to sing.

Blind Trust: The poem warns us not to follow every critic or “expert” blindly; some people offer advice only to serve themselves.

Character sketches:

The Frog - The frog is clever but selfish and jealous. He thinks he is a great singer, though his voice is harsh. When the nightingale becomes popular, he feels threatened. He tricks her by pretending to be a maestro and teacher and controls her singing. He is rude, greedy, and uses her for his own benefit. He represents commercial opportunism and self-interest.

The nightingale – The nightingale is sweet, innocent, and a beautiful singer. She symbolises pure, spontaneous talent and vulnerability. She becomes popular because of her melodious voice. However, she lacks confidence and easily trusts the frog. She follows his advice blindly and loses her natural

talent. She succumbs to self-doubt and overwork when coached by the Frog, illustrating how external pressure erases creativity and talent. She teaches us to believe in ourselves and not be easily influenced by others.

Villagers and audience - Function as mirrors of social taste and market pressures. The crowd shows how people can be easily influenced, impatient, and sometimes responsible for putting pressure on others without understanding their feelings.

Moral of the Story

True art requires a safe space and an appreciative audience. The poem cautions against allowing talent to be managed or crushed by jealous, incompetent, and manipulative individuals. Talent is useless without the courage to stand up for yourself. Don't let the "frogs" of the world silence your song.

Textual question- answers.

On the basis of your understanding of the poem, complete the sentences given below by choosing the appropriate option.

1. The frog's aim was to

- (a) make the nightingale a sensation
- (b) make the nightingale as good a singer as him
- (c) maintain his supremacy in the bog
- (d) make a lot of money

2. The animals reacted to the nightingale's song with

- (a) hatred
- (b) admiration
- (c) indifference
- (d) suggestions for improvement

3. The nightingale accepted the frog's tutelage as she

- (a) was not confident of herself
- (b) wanted to become as good a singer as the frog
- (c) wanted to become a professional singer
- (d) was not a resident of Bingle Bog

4. Where did the frog live?

- A. in a house
- B. in the Bingle bog**
- C. in a marsh
- D. none of these

5. Identify the use of Antithesis in the poem-

- A. awn and awn and awn
- B. Blared out from the sumac tree
- C. Croaked away in Bingle Bog
- D. dusk to dawn**

6.. Find a synonym for 'sang'

- A. mistrelled
- B. elation
- C. cacophony
- D. loathed

7. How did the animals of the bog try to stop the frog from singing?

- A. they hit it with stones, sticks and bricks**
- B. they killed it
- C. they sued it
- D. All of these

8. Where did the nightingale sit and sang?

- A. on a mango tree
- B. on an oak tree

C. on a sumac tree

D. on a carob tree

9. Which of the following is a synonym for 'rapt'?

A. scolded

B. trapped

C. closed

D. spellbound

10. Why did the frog scold the bird?

A. because she earned a lot

B. he wanted her voice to be stronger

C. he wanted to improve her song

D. he was concerned about her health .

11. Which figure of speech has been used-

"Toads and teals and tiddlers, captured

By her voice, cheered on, enraptured:"

A. metaphor

B. simile

C. alliteration

D. all of these

12. Which of the following is NOT one of the expressions used by the animals of the bog to praise the nightingale's song?

A. Perfect!

B. Bravo!

C. Too divine!

D. Encore!

13. How did the frog introduced itself?

1. It owned the tree.

2. It was known for its splendid baritone

3. It wrote for the Bog Trumpet

4. It was the richest animal of the bog

A. All of them

B. 1, 3

C. 1, 2, 3

D. None of them

14. The nightingale compares the frog to _____

A. Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan

B. Mozart

C. Michael Jackson

D. Beethoven

15. Which of the following adjectives is NOT suitable for the frog?

A. heartless

B. greedy

C. clever

D. Melodious

10. Answer the following questions briefly.

(a) How did the creatures of Bingle bog react to the nightingale's singing?

Ans: The creatures of Bingle Bog favoured the nightingale's songs to a great extent. In fact, they gathered in crowds to hear the nightingale sing. Animals and birds, from far and wide, came to hear her sing her melodious songs.

(b) Which are the different ways in which the frog asserts his importance?

Ans: The frog asserts his importance by being authoritative, territorial and imposing. He pretended to be a great singer and he also said that he was the reporter of Bog 'Trumpet'. He boasted that he was a music critic and a musician like Mozart and was ready to train her.

(c) Why is the frog's joy both sweet and bitter?

Ans: The joy of the frog was sweet as the nightingale could gather so many people to attend her concert. The more the audience, the more would be the earning, which the nightingale was bound to pay to the frog as tuition fees. Moreover, he was happy that he succeeds in torturing the bird and pushing her towards death. However, it was bitter as he knew deep within his heart that the nightingale's talent surpassed his own and thus, nobody as great as the present audience had ever come to hear him from far and wide. It was pure jealousy.

(d) Why was the frog angry?

Ans: The frog was angry because the nightingale had ceased to sing melodiously. Her song was so dull that no one liked it. This had suddenly crashed the income of frog.

(e) How did the frog become the unrivalled king of the bog again?

Ans: The frog became the unrivalled king of Bingle Bog, after the death of the nightingale. Now no bird or animal would compete with the frog in singing. Secondly, all of them over there were greatly scared of him

f) It is the nightingale's gullible nature that brings about its death. Comment.

Answer: The nightingale believed blindly whatever the frog told in his appreciation. She never tried to know the fact. She failed to look through the conspiracy of the frog. Being credulous, she came to the conclusion that the frog was a better singer. So, she herself was responsible for her death.

g) What message does the poet wish to give in the poem, "The Frog and the Nightingale"?

Answer: Credulous and docile people always suffer in this world. Owing to the lack of self-confidence. They are always misguided by others, and they always suffer disaster ultimately. The Nightingale never knew her virtues. She could not realise that she was far better than the frog. So, the crafty frog exploited her and caused her death.

Long Answer Type Questions .

Question 1. The frog, who was not at all talented, ruled in the end and the nightingale, who possessed the fineness and versatility of voice, died. Explain the irony of the statement, highlighting the values the frog should have possessed. (HOTS)

Answer: The frog, who was not at all talented, ruled in the end by dint of his cunningness and wickedness. He was jealous of the nightingale and hatched a plot to get rid of her. He was dismissive and condescending and treated the nightingale as a stupid creature. The irony in the statement is that the frog was the one who tried to teach the nightingale to 'sing differently'. He did not let her song to be her own. On the other hand, the nightingale was a meek and submissive creature who lacked confidence. Her gullibility and credulity made her an easy prey to the cunningness of the frog. Despite having the fineness and versatility of her voice, the nightingale met a fitting end as she was truly brainless. The frog philosophized that one's song must be one's own. One should realise his self worth and should not think low of oneself.

Question 2. The poem, 'The Frog and the Nightingale' highlights the fact that lack of confidence can lead to disaster. Keeping this in mind, elaborate the statement: 'If you accept yourself, the whole World accepts you'. (HOTS)

Answer: "If you accept yourself, the whole world accepts you" teaches us that one should exercise one's reasoning without letting others lead us blindly. If one has self-confidence the one can win the whole world. Without self-confidence nobody can succeed in life. You can hold the Infinity into your palm only if you have the confidence in yourself. In the context of the poem, the Nightingale was herself responsible for her downfall and death, because she did not have faith in her ability and did not have the brains to realise the enormity of her talent.

Question 3. Attempt a character portrayal of the frog on the basis of your reading of the poem.

Ans-*The secret to success is confidence in oneself.* This may be attributed to the frog's personality, who has the ability to make any bad situation work in his favour. He claims to be the only person in his bog who has a "splendid baritone." He wants to continue being the unmatched musical maestro of the bog. This is clear from the way he treated the nightingale who unintentionally dared to question his authority.

He is aware of all cunning techniques and understands when to use aggression and when to be kind. He makes such an impression on the nightingale by his clever manipulations that she thinks that he is an expert and compares him to Mozart. Once she agrees to accept him as her trainer, he starts using all tactics to dominate her. He corrects, belittles, and criticises her in every manner imaginable to the point that the poor creature loses all sense of self-worth and eventually passes away. He is not only cunning but manipulating too. By selling her tunes to others who came to hear her music, he earns money. Nowadays, there are people like the frog in every nook and corner of society. The poet has cautioned the readers to beware of such deceptive companions.

Poetic Devices used in the poem .

1. **Alliteration** –

'Bingle bog' , 'crass cacophony'

'his heart's'

'Next night'

'bad – but'

'Now the nightingale'

Scarf and sash etc.

2. **Allusion** – The nightingale makes a reference to a famous classical composer, Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart: "And you are Mozart in disguise / Come to earth before my eyes". The poet makes a reference to famous titles – 'Owl of sandwich' refers to the Earl of Sandwich, 'Duck of Kent' refers to the Duke of Kent, 'Mallard and Milady Trent' refer to My Lord and My Lady of Trent.

3. **Anaphora** – repetition of 'far too' in the start of line 3 and 4.

4. **Antithesis** – 'dusk' 'dawn', now then, up and down, sweet and bitter, 'morning' 'night'

5. **Imagery**- 'Ladies with tiaras glittering In the interval sat twittering' – The reader experiences visual and aural imagery by imagining the royal audience wearing royal tiaras and chatting.
'The sky in moonlit and a nightingale is sitting on a sumac tree, singing a melodious song.'
6. **Metaphor** – a comparison between two things without using like or as. – "This is a fairy tale and you're Mozart in disguise"
7. **Onomatopoeia**- 'croaked' is the sound produced by the frog, 'Koo-oh-ah! Ko-ash! Ko-ash' is the sound produced by the frog and the nightingale.
8. **Personification** – The frog has been personified – 'I wield my pen'
9. **Repetition** – awn and awn and awn, 'Did you... did you', 'ko-ash! Ko-ash', 'Day by day', 'Night on night'
10. Rhyme scheme-aa bb cc
11. **Transferred epithet** – 'And the crass cacophony Blared out from the sumac tree'.

Key Vocabulary and Meanings

Bog: A wet, muddy area.

Cacophony: Loud, unpleasant sound

Minstrel led: Sang or performed, often in a poetic sense.

Loathed: Hated intensely.

Elation: Great pride and joy.

Rapt: Totally focused or fascinated.

Serenaded: Sang a beautiful song.

Enraptured: Filled with delight.

Baritone: A deep, male singing voice.

Panache: Confident, stylish manner.

Morose: Miserable or gloomy.

Prone: Liable or likely to do something (e.g., "prone to influence").

Trills: Rapidly alternating musical notes.

Sumac: A type of tree (the setting for the performance).

Avid: Eager or enthusiastic.

Credulous: Too ready to believe things, gullible.

